

ACCESSIBILITY CONFORMANCE REPORT

ADA & Section 508 Accessibility Audit

Internet Crime Complaint Center — ic3.gov
Homepage & “File a Complaint” Terms Modal

AUDIT DATE	May 24, 2026
CONFORMANCE TARGET	WCAG 2.1 Level AA
REGULATORY BASIS	Section 508 of the Rehabilitation Act · ADA Title II
SCOPE	IC3 homepage and the modal Terms & Conditions dialog launched from the “File A Complaint” control
METHOD	Manual code & assistive-technology review (markup, ARIA, focus order, contrast)
REPORT STATUS	Final

About this report. This audit consolidates two scoped assessments — the public homepage and the Terms & Conditions modal — into a single conformance record. Each finding is classified by severity, mapped to the governing WCAG 2.1 success criterion, and paired with a concrete remediation. A prioritized roadmap and recommended ongoing-testing program follow the detailed findings.

Executive Summary

The IC3 properties are built on the U.S. Web Design System (USWDS), which provides a strong structural and semantic foundation: correct landmarks, a valid language declaration, a working skip link, descriptive page titles, and an exemplary data-equivalent alternative text on the losses chart. The platform is fundamentally sound and the great majority of defects are low-effort, code-level corrections rather than architectural rework.

That said, the review identified **conformance failures that warrant prompt attention**. On the homepage these center on document structure (a duplicate `<h1>`, broken heading order) and on a small set of controls that are not correctly named or are built from invalid markup. The Terms & Conditions modal carries the more serious cluster: its dialog semantics are placed on the wrong element, `aria-modal` is absent, there is no dedicated close control, and the dialog can overflow the viewport. Together these can prevent a screen-reader or keyboard-only user from understanding, navigating, or exiting the dialog that gates the entire complaint-filing process.

None of the issues require redesign. All are remediable with targeted markup and CSS changes, most rated low effort. Addressing the ten Critical findings first will resolve the highest-impact barriers and move both properties substantially toward WCAG 2.1 AA conformance.

Findings at a Glance



30 total findings across both surfaces — 20 on the homepage, 10 in the Terms & Conditions modal. Severity reflects user impact and likelihood of blocking task completion, not engineering effort.

Severity Definitions

SEVERITY	MEANING
Critical	A defect that blocks or materially impairs access for assistive-technology or keyboard users, or that violates a Level A/AA criterion in a way likely to prevent task completion. Fix first.
Significant	A real barrier or ambiguity that degrades the experience for affected users but generally has a workaround. Should be fixed in the same remediation cycle.
Moderate	A conformance gap or risk that is borderline, situational, or dependent on configuration. Worth correcting to harden compliance.

Low /
Best Practice

Not a clear failure, but an enhancement that improves robustness, clarity, or cross-browser reliability.

Homepage — ic3.gov

20 findings · 6 Critical · 6 Significant · 5 Moderate · 3 Best Practice

What's Working Well

- ✓ **Semantic structure.** A single `<main>` landmark, two labeled `<nav>` elements (Primary / Footer), plus `<header>`, `<footer>`, and a `<search>` landmark are all present and correctly implemented.
- ✓ **Language declaration.** `<html lang="en">` is set, enabling screen readers to select the correct speech engine.
- ✓ **Skip navigation.** A “Skip to content” link targets `#main-content`, which resolves to the real `<main>` element.
- ✓ **Descriptive page title.** “Home Page — Internet Crime Complaint Center (IC3).”
- ✓ **Responsive viewport.** Zoom is not disabled — no `user-scalable=no` — so text can be enlarged.
- ✓ **Decorative images handled correctly.** The U.S. flag, .gov icon, and HTTPS lock each carry `alt=""` and `aria-hidden="true"`.
- ✓ **Exemplary chart alternative text.** The losses chart includes a detailed, data-equivalent description of all five data points.
- ✓ **Navigation dropdowns.** The Public / Industry / Crime Info buttons correctly expose `aria-expanded` and `aria-controls`.
- ✓ **Search field label.** The input has a matching `<label for="search-field">` and proper `type="search"`.
- ✓ **Emergency callout.** The 911 box uses `role="alert"` for immediate announcement.
- ✓ **Footer social links.** Facebook, X, YouTube, LinkedIn, and Instagram use visible text names rather than icon-only links.

• Critical — Must Fix

A-1 Two `<h1>` elements on the page

The page declares two top-level headings: “Welcome to the Internet Crime Complaint Center” (the page title) and “FBI” (in the footer logo area). A page must expose exactly one `<h1>`; a second one corrupts the document outline that screen-reader users rely on to orient themselves.

Fix: Demote the footer “FBI” heading to an `<h2>` within its own section, or render it as a `<span>` if it is purely decorative — the FBI seal image already carries `alt="FBI Seal"`.

WCAG 1.3.1 / 2.4.6

Effort: Low

A-2 Broken heading hierarchy in the footer

After the body’s `<h2>` headings, the footer column titles (IC3, FBI, DOJ, Contact the FBI Press Office) are marked as `<h4>` with no intervening `<h3>` — a skip from H2 to H4. Separately, the footer “FBI” `<h1>` is immediately followed by an `<h3>`, skipping H2 entirely. Both break the logical reading order.

Fix: Re-level the footer headings to follow a continuous outline (`<h2>` or `<h3>` as appropriate) with no skipped levels.

WCAG 1.3.1

Effort: Low

A-3 Terms modal is not a native dialog and lacks `aria-modal`

The Terms & Conditions modal is a `<div class="usa-modal-wrapper">` with `tabindex="-1"` but no `aria-modal="true"`. In virtual/browse mode, screen readers will not be prevented from reading the content behind the overlay.

Fix: Convert to a native `<dialog>` element, or at minimum apply `role="dialog"` and `aria-modal="true"` to the dialog element. (See the modal-specific findings in Part B for the full correction.)

WCAG 4.1.2

Effort: Low

A-4 Header logo link has no meaningful accessible name

The header link `<a href="/Home/Index">` wraps an image with `alt="IC3 Logo"`. A screen reader announces "IC3 Logo, link," which describes the picture rather than the link's purpose, leaving the primary home control ambiguous as a navigation element.

Fix: Set the image `alt` (or an `aria-label` on the `<a>`) to communicate destination, e.g. "Internet Crime Complaint Center (IC3) — Home."

WCAG 2.4.4 / 4.1.2

Effort: Low

A-5 Invalid `href` attribute on a `<button>`

The "File A Complaint" control is a `<button>` carrying `href="#fileTerms"`. The `href` attribute is not valid on `<button>` elements (only on `<a>`), producing invalid HTML that can behave unpredictably across assistive technologies.

Fix: Use `<button type="button">` with a JavaScript click handler, or restructure as an `<a>` styled as a button.

WCAG 4.1.1

Effort: Low

A-6 Skip link is visually hidden — verify it appears on focus

The "Skip to content" link is positioned off-screen at `top: -60.8px`. This common pattern is only valid if the link returns into the viewport on keyboard focus. If the `:focus` state does not reveal it, sighted keyboard users receive no benefit from the skip mechanism.

Fix: Confirm (and enforce) that the `:focus` style moves the link back on-screen so it is visible when tabbed to.

WCAG 2.4.1

Effort: Low

• Significant — Should Fix

A-7 RSS feed links are not distinguishable

Both RSS links (`/PSA/RSS` and `/CSA/RSS`) derive their accessible name solely from a child image with `alt="RSS Symbol"` . A screen-reader user navigating a link list hears “RSS Symbol” twice, with no way to tell the feeds apart or know their destinations.

Fix: Add distinct names, e.g. `aria-label="Public Alerts RSS Feed"` and `aria-label="Industry Alerts RSS Feed"` on the respective links.

WCAG 2.4.4

Effort: Low

A-8 Decorative SVG icons expose `role="img"` with no label

The three SVG icons in “How You Can Help,” plus six other page SVGs, carry `role="img"` but no `aria-label` and no `aria-hidden` . A screen reader will attempt to announce them and find nothing, producing meaningless pauses or a read-aloud file name.

Fix: For decorative icons, remove `role="img"` and add `aria-hidden="true"` . For any that convey information, supply a descriptive `aria-label` . Audit all nine individually.

WCAG 1.1.1

Effort: Low

A-9 Mobile menu controls lack state and relationship attributes

The hamburger “Menu” button and the in-drawer “Close” button have no `aria-expanded` or `aria-controls` , so screen-reader users cannot tell whether the navigation drawer is open or which element it controls.

Fix: Add `aria-expanded` (toggled true/false) and `aria-controls` pointing to the navigation list’s ID.

WCAG 4.1.2

Effort: Low

A-10 Footer repeats identical link text across columns

The IC3, FBI, and DOJ columns each contain a “Home Page” (and other duplicated) link with the same visible text but different destinations. A link-list user hears “Home Page, Home Page, Home Page” with no differentiation.

Fix: Differentiate with `aria-label` or visually-hidden text, e.g. “IC3 Home Page,” “FBI Home Page,” “DOJ Home Page.”

WCAG 2.4.4

Effort: Low

A-11 Search button has no button-level accessible name

The search submit `<button>` relies on a child `<img alt="Search">` for its name. The computed name works today, but it breaks if the image fails to load or the alt is removed.

Fix: Add an explicit `aria-label="Search"` to the button element itself.

WCAG 4.1.2

Effort: Low

A-12 Search input is missing an `autocomplete` attribute

The `<input type="search">` has no `autocomplete` declaration. Although search fields are typically exempt, declaring intent explicitly ensures consistent assistive-technology behavior.

Fix: Add `autocomplete="off"` (or an appropriate token) to make the intent explicit.

WCAG 1.3.5

Effort: Low

• Moderate — Consider Fixing

A-13 Emergency alert icon may be read aloud

The exclamation/warning icon in the 911 alert box may be announced confusingly if it is a font icon without suppression.

Fix: Verify the icon element carries `aria-hidden="true"`.

WCAG 1.1.1

Effort: Low

A-14 Alert dates are not programmatically associated with headlines

Each alert card shows a month abbreviation and day in separate `<div>` elements, visually adjacent to a headline in a separate heading. There is no programmatic link, so a user navigating by heading hears the headline without its date.

Fix: Wrap the date in a `<time datetime="...">` element, or fold the date into the link text / `aria-label`.

WCAG 1.3.1

Effort: Medium

A-15 Full color-contrast sweep recommended

Spot checks pass — main-content links at $\approx 5.9:1$ and body text on white both clear AA. A complete automated sweep should still confirm edge cases such as text over the beige alert background and any text rendered over the chart graphic.

Fix: Run a dedicated contrast tool (axe / WAVE) across all color pairings and remediate any that fall below 4.5:1 (or 3:1 for large text).

WCAG 1.4.3

Effort: Low

A-16 Active navigation item is not marked `aria-current`

The current page (Home) is conveyed only by visual styling. Keyboard and screen-reader users receive no programmatic indication of their location in the navigation.

Fix: Add `aria-current="page"` to the active navigation link.

WCAG 2.4.4

Effort: Low

A-17 PDF links do not announce their file type

The Annual Report button and several industry-alert items link directly to PDF files with no indication of format. Users cannot anticipate a download versus a page navigation.

Fix: Append "(PDF)" to the visible link text or include it via `aria-label`.

WCAG 2.4.4

Effort: Low

• Low / Best Practice

A-18 No explicit `dir` attribute on `<html>`

Left-to-right is the default, but explicitly declaring `dir="ltr"` is a best practice for multilingual clarity.

Best Practice

Effort: Low

A-19 `<main>` lacks `tabindex="-1"` for the skip-link target

Without `tabindex="-1"` on the skip target, some browsers (notably Safari) scroll to `<main>` but do not move keyboard focus, rendering the skip link ineffective for those users.

Fix: Add `tabindex="-1"` to `<main id="main-content">`.

WCAG 2.4.1

Effort: Low

A-20 Content sections are not exposed as named regions

Several `<section>` elements (File a Complaint, How You Can Help, Recent IC3 Alerts) have no `aria-labelledby` or `aria-label`, so they are not navigable as landmarks.

Fix: Add `aria-labelledby` on each section pointing to its heading ID.

WCAG 1.3.6

Effort: Low

Terms & Conditions Modal

Launched from "File A Complaint" · 10 findings · 4 Critical · 2 Significant · 2 Moderate · 2 Best Practice

What's Working Well

- ✓ **Background content is suppressed.** On open, `aria-hidden="true"` is applied to the `<header>`, `<main>`, and `<footer>`, and the body receives `usa-js-modal--active`.
- ✓ **Heading is associated.** The wrapper carries `aria-labelledby="fileTermsHeading"` and `aria-describedby="fileTermsDesc"`, both resolving to real elements.
- ✓ **A dialog role is present.** `role="dialog"` appears on the outer `<div id="fileTerms">`.
- ✓ **Focus enters the modal on open.** The inner `.usa-modal` has `tabindex="-1"` and receives programmatic focus.
- ✓ **Strong contrast on most elements.** Body text 17.22:1, alert text on yellow 15.42:1, Accept button 6.72:1, links 9.40:1 — all clear AA.
- ✓ **Overlay scrolls.** The `.usa-modal-overlay` uses `overflow-y: scroll`, helping small-screen users reach the buttons.
- ✓ **Warning glyph is decorative.** The triangle in the alert header is a CSS/font icon and is not separately announced.

• Critical — Must Fix

B-1 `aria-modal` is missing — screen readers can escape the dialog

Neither the wrapper nor the inner `.usa-modal` carries `aria-modal="true"`. In virtual/browse mode (NVDA, JAWS, older VoiceOver), the reading cursor is not confined to the dialog and can wander into behind-content. The `aria-hidden` approach alone is unreliable across the full range of assistive technologies.

Fix: Add `aria-modal="true"` to the element that carries `role="dialog"`.

WCAG 4.1.2

Effort: Low

B-2 `role="dialog"` is on the wrong element

The role hierarchy is split: `role="dialog"` and the labels sit on the outer `<div id="fileTerms">`, but focus lands on the *inner* `.usa-modal` div, which has no role. Screen readers derive dialog semantics from the focused element — so on open, focus enters a generic `<div>` and the user is never told they are inside a dialog.

Fix: Move `role="dialog"`, `aria-labelledby`, `aria-describedby`, and `aria-modal="true"` onto the inner `.usa-modal` div (the element with `tabindex="-1"` that receives focus), or merge the two divs. See the code sketch below.

WCAG 4.1.2

Effort: Low

B-3 No dedicated close / dismiss control

The only ways out of the modal are “Accept” and “Decline” — both consequential action buttons, not neutral dismiss controls. A user who wants to re-read the underlying page before deciding has no way to close the dialog without committing to a choice, and there is no visible affordance for an Escape-to-close behavior.

Fix: Add the standard USWDS close control, e.g. `<button class="usa-modal__close" aria-label="Close this dialog">`, that dismisses the modal and returns focus to the “File A Complaint” trigger.

WCAG 2.1.1 / 2.1.2

Effort: Low

B-4 Modal overflows the viewport — buttons may be unreachable

The modal content is 936 px tall against an 826 px viewport. The overlay scrolls, but the inner modal uses `overflow-y: visible` and `max-height: none`. On touch devices and at the 200% zoom required by WCAG 1.4.4, the Accept and Decline buttons may be clipped or require scrolling with no visual cue that more content exists.

Fix: Constrain the dialog with `max-height: 90vh; overflow-y: auto;` on `.usa-modal` (or `.usa-modal__content`) so it provides its own internal scrollbar.

WCAG 1.4.10 / 2.1.1

Effort: Low

• Significant — Should Fix

B-5 Focus lands on a generic container, not the first interactive element

On open, focus moves to the generic `.usa-modal` container. Combined with the misplaced role (B-2), a screen-reader user hears the modal's full text (700+ characters) dumped in a single announcement before any dialog semantics are conveyed, with no opportunity to interrupt.

Fix: Once B-2 is resolved, optionally `autofocus` the “Accept” button, or ensure the focused container announces its role immediately on entry.

WCAG 2.4.3

Effort: Low

B-6 In-modal links open new tabs without warning

The “FAQ” and “Privacy Policy” links use `target="_blank"` with no external-link icon, hidden text, or label indicating a new tab. This is disorienting for screen-reader and cognitive-disability users, especially mid-dialog.

Fix: Add visually-hidden text such as `<span class="usa-sr-only">(opens in new tab)</span>`, or an `aria-label` like “FAQ (opens in new tab).”

WCAG 3.2.2

Effort: Low

• Moderate — Consider Fixing

B-7 “Decline” button contrast is borderline (4.59:1)

White text on the medium-gray Decline background yields 4.59:1 — passing AA for normal text by only 0.09. Subpixel anti-aliasing, dark-mode overrides, or display calibration could push it below threshold on a high-stakes control.

Fix: Darken the background to at least `rgb(96, 100, 104)` for a safer margin.

WCAG 1.4.3

Effort: Low

B-8 Heading line-height is smaller than its font-size

The “Terms and Conditions” heading computes to `font-size: 23.36px` with `line-height: 21.02px` — a 0.9 ratio. WCAG 1.4.12 requires line height of at least 1.5× the font size without loss of content when users adjust text spacing; the current value risks clipping under custom scaling.

Fix: Set the heading `line-height` to at least 1.2 (preferably 1.5).

WCAG 1.4.12

Effort: Low

• Low / Best Practice

B-9 “Decline” button has no `id`

“Accept” carries `id="acceptFile"` but “Decline” has none. This does not affect assistive technology — the visible text serves as the accessible name — but it makes the control harder to target for automated testing, analytics, and future `aria-controls` references.

Fix: Add a stable `id` to the Decline button.

Best Practice

Effort: Low

B-10 Skip link is suppressed while the modal is open

When the modal opens, the header skip link receives `aria-hidden="true"` as part of background suppression. This is correct *while* the modal traps focus, but the suppression must be applied and removed dynamically in response to open/close events, never statically.

Fix: Verify the `aria-hidden` toggle is bound to modal open/close and does not persist after the dialog closes.

WCAG 2.4.1

Effort: Low

Quick-Fix Code Sketch — Findings B-1 & B-2

The single most impactful change is consolidating the dialog semantics onto the element that actually receives focus:

CURRENT (BROKEN SPLIT)	CORRECTED (ROLE ON THE FOCUSED ELEMENT)
<div id="fileTerms" role="dialog" aria-labelledby="fileTermsHeading" aria-describedby="fileTermsDesc"> <div class="usa-modal" tabindex="-1"> <!-- gets focus, but has no role -->	<div id="fileTerms"> <div class="usa-modal" tabindex="-1" role="dialog" aria-modal="true" aria-labelledby="fileTermsHeading" aria-describedby="fileTermsDesc">

SECTION 3

Prioritized Remediation Roadmap

Findings are sequenced by user impact. Resolving Phase 1 (the ten Critical items) removes every barrier currently capable of blocking task completion for assistive-technology or keyboard users. Phases 2 and 3 harden conformance and polish robustness. Nearly all items are low-effort, code-level edits.

Phase 1 — Critical (fix first)

ID	FINDING	WCAG	EFFORT
A-1	Remove the duplicate <code><h1></code>	1.3.1 / 2.4.6	Low
A-2	Repair footer heading hierarchy	1.3.1	Low
A-3	Give the Terms modal proper dialog semantics	4.1.2	Low
A-4	Provide a meaningful logo-link name	2.4.4 / 4.1.2	Low
A-5	Replace invalid <code><button href></code>	4.1.1	Low
A-6	Ensure skip link appears on focus	2.4.1	Low
B-1	Add <code>aria-modal="true"</code> to the dialog	4.1.2	Low
B-2	Move <code>role="dialog"</code> onto the focused element	4.1.2	Low
B-3	Add a dedicated close button	2.1.1 / 2.1.2	Low
B-4	Constrain modal height with internal scroll	1.4.10 / 2.1.1	Low

Phase 2 — Significant

ID	FINDING	WCAG	EFFORT
A-7	Distinguish the two RSS feed links	2.4.4	Low
A-8	Hide or label decorative SVG icons	1.1.1	Low
A-9	Add state attributes to mobile menu controls	4.1.2	Low
A-10	Differentiate duplicate footer link text	2.4.4	Low
A-11	Add a button-level name to search	4.1.2	Low
A-12	Declare <code>autocomplete</code> on the search field	1.3.5	Low

B-5	Set initial focus to the first interactive element	2.4.3	Low
B-6	Warn when modal links open new tabs	3.2.2	Low

Phase 3 — Moderate & Best Practice

ID	FINDING	WCAG	EFFORT
A-13	Suppress the alert-box icon from screen readers	1.1.1	Low
A-14	Associate alert dates with their headlines	1.3.1	Medium
A-15	Run a full automated contrast sweep	1.4.3	Low
A-16	Mark the active nav item with <code>aria-current</code>	2.4.4	Low
A-17	Indicate PDF file type on links	2.4.4	Low
A-18	Add explicit <code>dir="ltr"</code>	Best practice	Low
A-19	Add <code>tabindex="-1"</code> to <code><main></code>	2.4.1	Low
A-20	Expose content sections as named regions	1.3.6	Low
B-7	Darken the Decline button background	1.4.3	Low
B-8	Increase the modal heading line-height	1.4.12	Low
B-9	Add an <code>id</code> to the Decline button	Best practice	Low
B-10	Bind skip-link suppression to modal events	2.4.1	Low

SECTION 4

Ongoing Testing Program

This audit was a manual, code- and AT-level review of two surfaces. To sustain conformance as the site evolves — and to cover flows not examined in depth here, most importantly the complaint-filing process beyond its entry modal — pair automated scanning with structured manual testing.

LAYER	RECOMMENDED PRACTICE
Automated scanning	Run axe DevTools, WAVE, or axe-core in CI on every page and on each step of the complaint-filing flow. Treat new violations as build-blocking regressions.
Keyboard-only testing	Tab through every interactive element confirming visible focus, logical order, no traps, and a working skip link — with particular attention to the Terms modal open/close cycle.

Screen-reader testing	Validate with NVDA + Firefox and VoiceOver + Safari at minimum; add JAWS + Chrome where available. Confirm dialog announcement, focus return, and landmark navigation.
Zoom & reflow	Verify 200% zoom and 400% reflow (WCAG 1.4.4 / 1.4.10) with no clipped controls — re-test the modal after the B-4 height fix.
Manual contrast	Complete the full contrast sweep noted in A-15, including text over background images and graphics.

Scope & disclaimer. This report reflects a point-in-time review of the IC3 homepage and the Terms & Conditions modal as observed on the audit date. It does not constitute legal advice or a certification of compliance. WCAG conformance is determined per page and per process; remediating the findings herein advances — but does not by itself guarantee — full WCAG 2.1 AA, Section 508, or ADA Title II conformance across the entire property. Re-test after remediation and extend coverage to the complete complaint-filing workflow.